



Here's how design is leading Tata Motors' renaissance

Mr. Pratap Bose, Head of Design at Tata Motors sheds light on the company's design language, breaking long-established notions and gearing up for the future.

Souvik Das | souvik@digit.in

It has been well over a year since the Tata Tiago rolled out on to the Indian streets. Immediately, it caught fancy of a then-surprisingly large number of car buyers, buoyed by a lightweight body, new generation connectivity, fairly posh interiors and peppy drive reviews across the automotive journalism fraternity. At the centre of its success, though, was how the Tiago looked.

As against a lot of the older generation of Tata Motors' consumer vehicles, the Tata Tiago looked young. The Indian car maker even got the legendary Lionel Messi on board as its global brand ambassador, a clear mark of its youth-oriented intentions. Tata's older crop of cars were always known to be quite solidly built, but somewhat lacked the chirpy, young and instantly

appealing design statements that other car makers in India were presenting. You'd only need to look as far as the Aria to know what I'm talking about.

"We were not in the consideration for most car buyers, and that is what we had to change first," states Mr. Pratap Bose, Tata Motors' design chief. "Hence, the Impact design philosophy was born. It was meant to make an instant impact. Seeing the car's photo should instantly garner interest, (and) it is only then that they (the buyers) would take test drives, and that would convert to buying decisions."

Bose has been with Tata Motors for over a decade now, and in his time, has seen a huge upheaval of consumer vehicle strategies and how the role of car design has escalated and evolved at Tata. "The process started about four

and half years ago when we needed to change the market position of Tata," he says. "For example, the younger demographic or women were not being attracted to Tata."

So, how did the change come along?

"MIND SHARE LEADS TO MARKET SHARE"

As Bose puts it, the key to garnering interest among customers is through the immediate appeal of a car – its design. When a car launches and the initial photographs are rolled out, it needs to look the part. For instance, in

the highly popular SUV and crossover segments in India, a huge section of car buyers are opting for strong design cues, while not being overtly loud in angles and lines.

"If you look at the Hexa, you will see that it is all about being strong, while not being aggressive. We stay away from aggression in our design, which



Mr. Pratap Bose, Head of Design, Tata Motors